11+ Comprehension

11+ Comprehension Mastery Guide

How to read faster, find answers accurately, and handle every question type

WHAT THIS GUIDE COVERS

A four-phase reading method, a complete breakdown of the five distractor traps used to catch out unprepared students, a four-step inference system, a vocabulary decoding method, two practice passages with model summaries, and a high-frequency word reference table.

GL ASSESSMENT · SHARE WITH FAMILIES Comprehension · 11+ English

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What Makes Comprehension Hard

Most students read a passage and then search for answers. Top-performing students do the opposite: they identify what the questions are looking for before they read a single word of the passage. This guide replaces instinctive, linear reading with a structured method that is faster, more accurate, and far more resistant to the distractor traps that GL Assessment builds deliberately into every paper.

The five sections below each address a specific, named problem. Work through them in order the first time. After that, use them as a reference: return to the section that corresponds to the question type you are finding most difficult.

> *"The student who reads the questions before the passage is not cheating. They are doing exactly what the examiner expects a prepared candidate to do."*

01 Comprehension

How to Read a Passage

6 min read · Section 01 of 05

Top-performing students do not read a text from start to finish at a uniform pace. They use a four-phase approach that builds a mental map of the passage before committing to any answer.

1 PHASE

Read the Questions First

Identify what you are looking for before reading the passage. This turns reading into a targeted search.

1. Read the question stems only. Ignore the A to E answer options entirely to avoid priming your brain with incorrect information.
2. Circle any anchors mentioned in the questions: specific dates, capitalised proper nouns, or line references.
3. Commit these anchors to memory. They will jump out at you visually during the passage reading.

2 PHASE

Use a Pencil to Track Every Word

Physical tracking prevents regression: the habit of re-reading a line because your focus drifted.

1. Place a pencil under each line as you read and move it steadily forward.
2. Maintain a brisk, consistent pace. Do not slow down unless you are in Intensive Mode (see Phase 3).
3. If you lose your place, return to the last anchor word you remember, not the beginning of the paragraph.

3 PHASE

Switch Between Scan and Intensive Mode

Never read the whole passage at one uniform speed. The question type tells you which mode to use.

1. Use Scan Mode for retrieval tasks (finding a name, a date, or a fact). Move your eyes vertically down the page rather than horizontally across each line.
2. Use Intensive Mode for inference tasks. Slow your reading speed when you reach a character's internal thoughts, complex metaphors, or a paragraph where the mood shifts.
3. Switch modes deliberately. Scanning an inference paragraph and reading intensively through a factual one both cost marks.

4 PHASE

Write One Anchor Word Per Paragraph

A single word in the margin after each paragraph creates a fast index you can use during the question phase.

1. Pause for two seconds after finishing each paragraph.
2. Write one word in the margin that captures that paragraph's core purpose. Examples: Atmosphere, Conflict, Turning-Point, Description, Resolution.
3. When a question asks about something specific, scan your margin notes first. This makes returning to the correct part of the text significantly faster.

The most important rule in this section

Never read an entire passage at a uniform speed. Flat, undifferentiated reading is the single most common habit that separates a 60% score from an 85% score. Scan for facts, slow down for inference, and always return to the text before committing to an answer.

02 Comprehension

The Five Answer Traps

5 min read · Section 02 of 05

GL Assessment distractors are deliberately engineered to catch students who read superficially. Knowing the name and mechanism of each trap is the only reliable defence against it.

The distractors in a well-constructed GL paper are not random wrong answers. Each one exploits a specific reading habit: the tendency to stop at a familiar word, to rely on outside knowledge, or to accept the first option that sounds plausible. The table below names each trap, explains how it works, and gives the counter-strategy.

THE FIVE DISTRACTOR TRAPS

Trap Name	What it does	How to beat it
The Literal Lure	Uses words copied verbatim from the passage but applies them to the wrong character, wrong time, or wrong event.	Always check the context around the quoted words, not just the words themselves.
The External Inference	An answer that is factually true in real life but has no evidence in the provided passage.	If you cannot point to a specific line that supports it, discard it. The passage is the only source of truth.
The Intensity Trap	Correctly identifies a theme or emotion but uses a word that is too extreme for what the text actually supports.	Check the exact degree of the emotion or action in the passage. 'Annoyed' and 'furious' are not interchangeable.
The Negative Logic Flip	Questions using NOT or EXCEPT. All distractors will be true statements from the text, designed to trigger a confirmation bias error.	Underline NOT or EXCEPT before reading the options. You are looking for the exception, not the rule.
The Scope Shifter	Offers a vivid, accurate detail from one part of the passage as the answer to a question asking for the best summary of the whole.	A best summary must cover beginning, middle, and end. A detail from one paragraph alone is never the right answer to a summary question.

How to use this table in practice

After getting a question wrong on a practice paper, identify which trap caught you and name it. This is more useful than simply noting the correct answer. Once you can name the trap that caught you, you will recognise it before it catches you again.

- The Literal Lure and the Intensity Trap are the two most common.
- The External Inference catches students who know a lot about the topic of the passage.
- The Scope Shifter specifically targets summary and best title questions.

03 Comprehension

How to Answer Inference Questions

5 min read · Section 03 of 05

An inference question asks you to work out something the author implies but does not state directly. The method below turns this into a structured, evidence-based process rather than a guess.

The key rule is this: every inference must be provable from the text. If you cannot find a specific word or phrase that supports your answer, you have either guessed or fallen for the External Inference trap. Use the four steps below on every inference question until the process becomes automatic.

1

Rephrase the Question as a Search Task

Convert the inference question into a physical evidence task. Instead of asking 'How does the character feel?', ask 'What physical symptoms or actions in lines 10 to 20 indicate how the character feels?' This makes the task concrete and searchable.

2

Find the Hinge Words

Scan the relevant lines for hinge words: but, yet, however, suddenly, despite, although, until. These words signal a shift in the character's mood, the plot direction, or the author's tone. The inference is almost always located at or immediately after a hinge word.

3

Apply the Inference Formula

Once you have found a textual clue, apply: Textual Clue + What I Know = Inference. Example: 'The character's knuckles were white' (clue) + people grip tightly when afraid (knowledge) = the character is frightened (inference). The formula prevents guessing because it requires a named clue.

4

Run the Exclusion Audit

Before selecting your answer, run through the remaining options and ask: can I find specific words in the text that prove this option? If the answer is no for any option, discard it. The correct answer is the one you can point to, not the one that sounds most reasonable.

What inference is not

Inference is not guessing based on what seems likely. It is not using your general knowledge about a topic. It is not selecting the option that sounds most dramatic or emotionally resonant. It is finding the smallest piece of textual evidence that proves a conclusion, and nothing more.

04 Comprehension

How to Decode Difficult Vocabulary

5 min read · Section 04 of 05

The 11+ uses academic vocabulary that most students have not encountered in conversation. The IDEAS method gives you five different ways to work out the meaning of an unfamiliar word using only the text around it.

You do not need to know the word before the exam. You need to be able to decode it from the context. The five strategies below cover every type of contextual clue an author might leave. Try them in order: Inference first, then Definition, and so on. Most words can be decoded within the first two or three steps.

I — Inference

Does the general mood or topic of the paragraph suggest a meaning? Read the surrounding sentences and ask: what kind of word would make sense in this context?

D — Definition

Does the author define the word in the sentence immediately after it? Writers often introduce a difficult word and then clarify it with a simpler restatement.

E — Example

Does the text provide a list or example that illustrates what the word means? If a difficult word is followed by examples of the same category, the word names that category.

A — Antonym

Look for contrast words nearby: unlike, whereas, but, however, in contrast. The word after the contrast signal often means the opposite of the difficult word, which reveals its meaning.

S — Synonym

Is there a simpler word used nearby that means the same thing? Authors often pair a formal word with a more accessible equivalent in the same sentence or paragraph.

Try IDEAS in order, not all at once

Start with Inference every time. Ask: what kind of word would fit here given the mood of the paragraph? This alone solves the majority of vocabulary questions. Move to Definition, then Example, then Antonym, then Synonym only if the previous step did not yield a clear answer. Most words yield within the first two steps.

05 Comprehension

Practice Passages and Model Summaries

6 min read · Section 05 of 05

Apply the methods from Sections 01 to 04 to the two passages below before reading the model summaries. The summaries demonstrate how to avoid the Scope Shifter trap by covering the beginning, middle, and end of each passage in a single sentence.

For each passage: read the model summary question first ('What is the best one-sentence summary of this passage?'), then apply your Phase 1 anchors, use the appropriate reading mode, and write your own summary before comparing it to the model. The explanation below each model summary tells you why it works.

Passage A: Fiction

PASSAGE A Classic Fiction Extract

The mist was heavier yet when I got out upon the marshes, so that instead of my running at everything, everything seemed to run at me. This was very disagreeable to a guilty mind, for the gates and dykes and banks came bursting at me through the mist, as if they cried as plainly as could be, 'A boy with Somebody-else's pork pie!' The damp cold seemed riveted to my feet, as the iron was riveted to the leg of the man I was running to meet. I knew my way to the old Battery, but however fast I went, I couldn't warm my frozen limbs. Suddenly, the silence was shattered by a low, guttural growl. I stopped, my heart hammering against my ribs like a trapped bird. There, rising from the grey primordial vastness, was the figure of a man: soaked in water, smothered in mud, and lamed by stones. He stared at me with eyes that reflected a desperate, hollow hunger.

MODEL SUMMARY A

Consumed by guilt and battling the freezing marshland, the narrator travels to meet a convict but is suddenly startled by the arrival of a wretched, starving man.

Why this works:

This summary captures all three required elements: the emotional state (guilt), the setting (marshes, cold), and the concluding action (the encounter with the man). It avoids the Scope Shifter trap by not focusing only on the weather, only on the guilt, or only on the final encounter. A single sentence covering all three earns the marks.

Passage B: Non-Fiction

PASSAGE B Historical Report

The construction of the RMS Titanic began in March 1909 at the Harland and Wolff shipyard in Belfast. Designed to be the largest object ever to move on the water, the ship spanned 269 metres in length and 53 metres in height. While the builders claimed the vessel was 'practically unsinkable' due to its 16 watertight compartments, these bulkheads were tragically not capped at the top. On the night of April 14, 1912, despite receiving multiple ice

warnings, the ship maintained its course through a flat, moonless sea. This lack of visual markers made spotting icebergs nearly impossible for the lookouts. By the time the iceberg was sighted at 11:39 pm, the collision was unavoidable. The resulting disaster led to the loss of approximately 1,500 lives and prompted a complete overhaul of maritime safety regulations, including mandatory lifeboat capacity for every soul on board.

MODEL SUMMARY B

Originally celebrated as an engineering marvel with fatal design flaws, the Titanic's collision with an iceberg resulted in massive loss of life and a permanent change to maritime safety law.

Why this works:

This summary avoids focusing only on the size of the ship (a detail trap) or only on the collision (another detail trap). It covers construction and the design flaw, the event, and the lasting consequence. The phrase 'originally celebrated' captures the beginning, 'fatal design flaws' captures the middle problem, and 'permanent change to maritime safety law' captures the end. All three phases in one sentence.

How to practise with these passages

After writing your own summary, compare it to the model and ask three specific questions: Does mine cover the beginning? Does it cover the middle? Does it cover the end? If any one of the three is missing, your answer would fall into the Scope Shifter trap regardless of how accurate it is about the part it does cover.